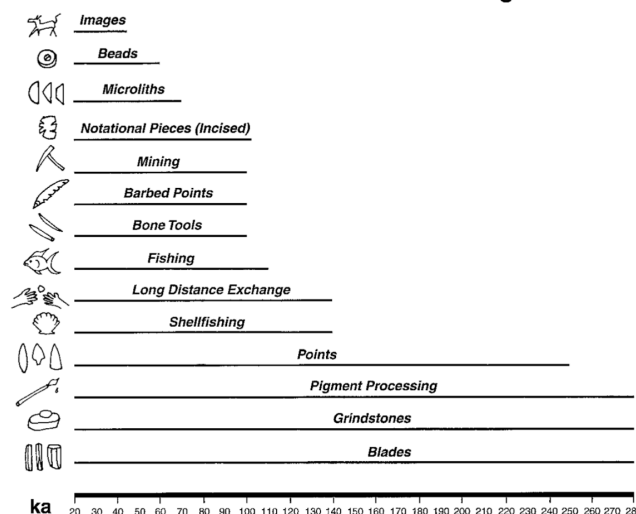


The Evolution of Modern Humans

All humans alive today belong to the species *Homo sapiens*; our closest cousins are the Neanderthals and Denisovans, species that became extinct by the end of the Paleolithic era—likely around 40,000 to 30,000 years ago. *Homo sapiens* evolved in Africa around 300,000 years ago from our ancestor species. The first *Homo sapiens* are termed “anatomically modern humans” (or, sometimes, “early modern humans”) to indicate that they shared our overall morphology. Importantly, these humans do not appear to have been fully like us in terms of behavior. Some advanced behaviors—including making art and tools of compound materials, and complex planning and abstract thought—are not in evidence in the archaeological record until much more recently. Although the origins and timing of modern behavior are still debated, evidence increasingly supports a model in which behavioral complexity arose gradually, with specific behaviors being added to the behavioral “tool kit” over time rather than being developed all together, beginning in the Middle Stone Age of Africa before 100,000 years ago. What is also clear from the archaeological record, however—especially the archaeological record of Europe—is that a greater number of complex behaviors are present together from around 50,000 years ago. It is at this time that fully behaviorally modern humans can be identified in the archaeological world across Africa and Eurasia; this is also the approximate date of the first arrival of humans in Australia, which represents the earliest well-documented open-sea voyage in human history.

Behavioral Innovations of the Middle Stone Age in Africa



Timing of the archaeological appearance of practices described as behaviorally “modern” (McBrearty and Brooks, 2000, p. 530). “ka” =

thousands of years.

Source: Journal of Human Evolution

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